

tions, typically with a clear plastic area containing crosshairs for precise tracing of drawings, followed by a basic stylus. Today, a graphics tablet is equipped with a stylus for all models and a mouse for all but the cheapest or smallest models, and typically has a wide variety of other accessories available too. Many tablets use a digital data stream to encode information on the pen, often transmitting a unique serial number, allowing the software to recognize if the user has multiple input devices, and assigns different properties (brush type, colour, etc) to each device.

4.1.1. Stylus

A modern stylus has a pressure sensitive tip capable of sensing many levels of pressure against the tablet. A very inexpensive tablet might be able to sense 256 levels of pressure, while a normal tablet 512 levels, and a professional tablet a full 1024 levels of pressure. The increase in sensitivity of the tablet tip allows more precise control, especially if software scaling is used to allow a large response to a mild increase in pressure. High-end tablets also measure the tilt of the pen, giving the angle from vertical along both the X and Y axis (typically up to 60 degrees), allowing the graphics program to change the shape or other attributes of the brush depending on how the stylus is held. Some manufacturers also sell a stylus that uses a ball-point pen cartridge in the tip, allowing the user to place a sheet of paper onto the tablet, and draw a hard-copy on the paper in addition to the digitised version.

4.1.2. Stylus Eraser

Many modern styli have an eraser-shaped tip on the top of the pen, and additional circuitry to allow the pen to be used upside-down with the eraser end against the tablet, often very similar or identical to the circuitry used for the tip. The pressure-sensitive eraser is typically assigned a function similar to a real eraser, removing recent or all layers of colouring from the image, although it can be assigned other functions, such as a differently shaped brush, a selection tool, or some other feature of the application.